# Supplementary depth repair — Library movement, Adi-Hindu mobilisation and social reform in Hyderabad State

Status: Original analytical supplement to an older shallow draft. This does not replace the existing chapter PDF or constitute independent academic approval. Verified core facts draw on Telangana SCERT Class VIII Social Studies (2022–23 edition) and the Telangana Government Oriental Manuscripts Library and Research Institute's institutional history, checked 25 October 2026.

## 1. Why a library movement was a social movement

In a princely state where official language, educational opportunity and public debate were unevenly distributed, a reading room was more than a place to store books. It created a relatively durable public space in which students, teachers, small traders and aspiring writers could encounter newspapers, discuss social problems and organise lectures. The political importance of such spaces depended on who could enter them, what languages they stocked and whether authorities permitted meetings. A library that circulated Telugu books could broaden access for some Telangana readers, while remaining inaccessible to women, non-literate labourers or people excluded by caste. Therefore the growth of libraries should be evaluated as a partial expansion of the public sphere, not automatically as mass democratisation.

Telangana SCERT identifies the Sri Krishnadevaraya Andhra Bhasha Nilayam, established in Hyderabad in 1901 by Komarraju Lakshmana Rao with Nayani Venkatarangarao and Ravichettu Ranga Rao, as a landmark in Telugu literary organisation. The historical point is not merely the year. A named institution shows how language-based cultural work acquired continuity through premises, collections and collective effort. The library connected printed works circulating from the Andhra region with readers in the Hyderabad dominion. That cross-regional circulation did not mean the two regions had identical political interests. Literary exchange and the later debate about employment safeguards operated on different planes.

## 2. Language, dignity and the 1921 episode

SCERT records an incident in 1921 at a meeting in Hyderabad's Viveka Vardhini College where a proposal made in Telugu was reportedly slighted in favour of English or Urdu. The incident matters because it illustrates how a language hierarchy could become a claim about dignity and equal participation. It should not be simplified into an assertion that every Urdu speaker opposed Telugu. Hyderabad was multilingual, and both Urdu and Telugu were used by internally diverse communities. The relevant political mechanism was exclusion from prestigious forums through unequal linguistic status.

The library movement answered that problem by circulating reading material and nurturing the ability to speak publicly in Telugu. But the creation of a Telugu-language public sphere was not the same as securing education for all classes. Reading rooms could be concentrated in towns and accessible mainly to educated men. A stronger historical evaluation asks which groups participated, which genres circulated, whether women had access, and whether literature addressed landlessness and caste discrimination. These questions make the movement socially intelligible rather than merely celebratory.

## 3. Andhra Jana Sangham and the diffusion of reading rooms

Telangana SCERT describes the Andhra Jana Sangham, associated with Madapati Hanumantha Rao and others in the 1920s, as encouraging libraries, reading rooms, students and Telugu manuscripts. Such activity joined cultural assertion to organisational skills: keeping membership lists, raising funds, inviting speakers and coordinating meetings. These skills could later be reused in broader social and political campaigns. However, the organisation's early educational objectives should not be retrospectively converted into a fully formed separate-Telangana demand. The historical meaning of an organisation must be anchored to its contemporary programme, not only its later legacy.

An analytical comparison helps. A newspaper can spread an argument quickly but may disappear after one issue; a library can sustain access to many publications over years; a public meeting allows collective deliberation but may be vulnerable to restrictions. The three forms reinforced each other. A movement with books but no readers remains narrow; readers without places to meet may remain isolated; meetings without durable records can struggle to build continuity. This is why libraries were important institutions in the social awakening of Hyderabad State.

## 4. Bhagya Reddy Varma and Adi-Hindu mobilisation

Bhagya Reddy Varma (1888–1939), born Maderi Bagaiah, is identified in Telangana SCERT as a prominent Dalit reformer. In 1906 he began Jagan Mitra Mandali, using popular performance to spread awareness and challenge caste humiliation. The Adi-Hindu framing asserted dignity and an alternative account of the place of oppressed communities in Indian society. The term should be explained as a reform movement's political vocabulary, not treated as an uncontested historical classification of ancient populations.

His work is especially important because it exposes the limits of a narrative focused only on elite language associations. For communities denied access to schools, public wells, temples or respectable employment, reform required changes in everyday social power. Educational initiatives, collective organisation and campaigns against the dedication of girls as devadasis or joginis were connected to the struggle against untouchability. SCERT notes efforts to obtain special educational funds from the Nizam's government. A balanced answer should examine both the movement's achievements and the institutional obstacles that limited access.

The gender dimension deserves its own analysis. A campaign against dedication practices addressed coercion and sexual exploitation, but meaningful emancipation also required schooling, livelihood alternatives, social protection and freedom from stigma. Repression of a harmful practice without support for affected women and girls could shift vulnerability rather than remove it. This is a general policy lesson drawn from the history; it is not a claim that all these measures were adopted in the period.

## 5. Different reform strategies and their social reach

Language associations, caste reform movements and agrarian mobilisation were neither identical nor wholly separate. A Telugu library could challenge linguistic marginalisation; an Adi-Hindu organisation could challenge caste exclusion; a peasant association could contest landlord power. A participant might be involved in more than one movement, yet the distribution of benefits could differ. For example, gaining permission to speak Telugu in an urban meeting would not necessarily eliminate forced labour in a village. Conversely, ending a coercive labour practice would not automatically make government education linguistically accessible.

The historian should therefore ask five questions of each organisation: Who founded it? What grievance did it identify? Which methods did it use? Who could participate? What evidence shows its

actual reach? This method prevents a list of names and dates from being mistaken for a social history. It also allows comparison without ranking movements solely by the later fame of their leaders.

## 6. Libraries as archives and the limits of retrospective evidence

The Telangana Government Oriental Manuscripts Library and Research Institute traces its institutional roots to an 1891 collection and the Asafia Library, later associated with the State Central Library. Its current holdings span multiple languages and demonstrate that Hyderabad's knowledge institutions cannot be described as exclusively Telugu or Urdu. However, the present institute's collection size and administrative status are contemporary facts; they cannot be projected backwards as exact holdings in 1901 or 1935.

A reliable answer distinguishes institutional continuity from numerical continuity. The existence of an old library does not prove that every village had reading facilities; a modern archive's manuscript collection does not establish how many people could read those manuscripts a century ago. Use official institutional histories for names and chronology, and supplement them with contemporary catalogues, membership records and newspapers when making claims about audience or political influence.

## 7. A structured mains synthesis

Background: Hyderabad's multilingual society had uneven educational and social access. Cultural mobilisation: the 1901 Bhasha Nilayam and later reading-room networks expanded Telugu print culture and spaces for discussion. Social reform: Bhagya Reddy Varma's Adi-Hindu mobilisation challenged caste humiliation, promoted education and opposed coercive dedication practices. Contrast: language, caste and gender inequalities required different but potentially complementary strategies. Limits: libraries were not universally accessible, and legal or cultural recognition did not by itself change material power. Conclusion: Telangana's socio-cultural awakening was a layered transformation of public communication and social claims, not a single homogeneous movement.

## Source audit and limitations

• Telangana SCERT, Class VIII Social Studies, 2022–23, https://scert.telangana.gov.in/pdf/publication/ebooks2019/8th%20social%2022-23%20part2%202022-23.pdf — official school-level account of Bhagya Reddy Varma, Jagan Mitra Mandali, library movement and language debates; secondary educational synthesis.

• Telangana SCERT, Class VIII Social Studies, https://www.scert.telangana.gov.in/pdf/publication/ebooks2019/8th%20social%20em.pdf — corroboration of 1901 library and Andhra Jana Sangham details.

• Telangana Government Oriental Manuscripts Library and Research Institute, https://tgomlri.telangana.gov.in/about — present institutional history; not a contemporary witness to all nineteenth-century claims.

Audit gate: This supplement has not received independent academic review. It is not a verified official PYQ source. Exact founding details, organisational membership and social outcomes should be rechecked against archival records before academic approval.